

Disarmament and International Security Committee

Background Guide

Committee Overview

The United Nation Disarmament and International Security Committee, also known as the First Committee is a United Nations Committee established in 1945 as one of the six general assemblies, dealing with disarmament and international security. It tackles thematics such as nuclear weapons, other weapons of mass destruction.

DISEC's main focus is the maintenance of international peace and security while promoting cooperation in order to strengthen stability through lower levels or armament. The committee works closely with UNDC and the Geneva-based Conference on Disarmament. It can also make recommendations to the UN members or the Security Council, however it cannot influence their decision directly, it may suggest topics to consider.

Definitions

Non-state armed group (NSAG's) : includes non-states groups or terrorist groups- designated by the United Nation Security Council. These groups contribute to conflicts and violences in regions at risk.

Ammunition Diversion: Refers to the unauthorized transfer of legally produced ammunition between state-controlled stockpiles to non-state actors

Topic Overview

The unauthorized transfer of conventional ammunition between state-controlled stockpiles, licensed markets, or conflict zones to non-state armed groups (NSAG's) is a critical issue regarding global security. The NSAG represents terrorist organizations, criminal syndicates, and other groups working outside of the state's formal military structure.

Ammunition diversions affect international peace and security, increase conflicts between states, and result in civilian casualties. Despite the ongoing international frameworks installed, corruption and inadequate regulation continues to enable the diversion of conventional ammunition.

Bloc Positions
Western Bloc(EU, USA, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, South Korea):

Western countries generally support stricter regulations on ammunition transfers, stronger border security, and greater international cooperation. These countries emphasize the importance of tracking ammunition and preventing it from reaching terrorist organizations and other armed groups. They also support improving transparency between countries and holding those involved in illegal ammunition trafficking accountable.[1]

African Union:

Many African countries face challenges with ammunition diversion due to ongoing conflicts, weak border security, and limited resources. Countries in regions such as the Sahel are particularly affected by armed groups obtaining ammunition through illegal networks.[2] African Union members generally support stronger regional cooperation and improved stockpile management. However, many also emphasize the need for financial assistance and training from the international community to effectively address these issues.[3]

Russia and China:

Russia and China generally emphasize national sovereignty and believe individual countries should have greater control over their own ammunition regulations. While both countries recognize the threat of illegal ammunition trafficking, they tend to favour solutions that do not interfere with domestic policies or national security. They also support maintaining the right of countries to legally trade and purchase ammunition for defence purposes.[4]

Historical analysis

The illegal transfer of ammunition has been a concern for the international community for decades, especially in regions experiencing armed conflict. In 2001, the United Nations introduced the Programme of Action on Small Arms and Light Weapons, encouraging countries to strengthen regulations and prevent illegal weapons trafficking. Although this agreement mainly focused on firearms, it helped establish international cooperation on arms control.[5]

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[1] https://www.amnesty.org/en/what-we-do/arms-control/
[2] https://www.visionofhumanity.org/how-illicit-economies-fund-terrorism/
[3] https://www.crisisgroup.org/rpt/africa/african-union-regional-bodies/297-how-spend-it-new-eu-funding-african-peace-and-security
[4] https://www.fmprc.gov.cn/mfa_eng/xw/wjbxw/202511/t20251127_11761653.html
[5] https://reliefweb.int/report/world/united-nations-launches-international-small-arms-control-standards-aim-boosting

In 2017, the UN Security Council adopted Resolution 2370, which addressed the growing concern of terrorist organizations obtaining weapons and ammunition through illegal networks. It encouraged countries to improve border security and strengthen measures to prevent these transfers.[6]

More recently, in 2023, the UN General Assembly adopted Resolution 78/47, establishing the Global Framework for Through-life Conventional Ammunition Management. This framework introduced 15 objectives aimed at improving ammunition security and preventing diversion.[7] However, since the framework is voluntary, countries are not legally required to follow all its recommendations, raising concerns about how effective it will be.

Current situation

Ammunition diversion continues to be a major international security issue, particularly in countries experiencing ongoing conflicts. Non-state armed groups often obtain ammunition through illegal trafficking networks, theft from military stockpiles, and unauthorized transfers. In regions such as the Sahel and the Middle East, political instability and weak government control have made it increasingly difficult to prevent ammunition from reaching armed groups.[8]

Although international agreements have been introduced to address this issue, many countries still struggle with enforcing regulations. Corruption, limited funding, and poorly secured ammunition stockpiles continue to create opportunities for illegal transfers.

The Global Framework for Through-life Conventional Ammunition Management, adopted in 2023, has encouraged countries to improve their ammunition security. However, differences in national regulations and available resources have made international cooperation difficult. As a result, the international community continues to face challenges in balancing national security, legal ammunition trade, and the prevention of illegal trafficking.[9]

Potential solution

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6 https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2009/10/security-council-unanimously-adopts-wide-ranging-anti-terrorism-resolution

7 https://www.smallarmssurvey.org/resource/global-framework-through-life-conventional-ammunition-management

8 https://reliefweb.int/report/niger/stray-bullets-aoav-applauds-new-research-how-diverted-ammunition-fuels-conflict-sahel

9 https://cic.nyu.edu/resources/inclusive-ammunition-management-a-practical-guide-for-gender-and-multi-stakeholder-cooperation-in-the-global-framework-for-through-life-conventional-ammunition-management/

One possible solution to ammunition diversion is improving how countries track and store their ammunition. Governments could introduce stronger inventory systems, conduct regular inspections of military stockpiles and overall improve security at storage facilities.[10] This would make it easier to identify missing ammunition and reduce the risk of theft.

Another solution involves increasing cooperation between countries, particularly those sharing borders with conflict-affected regions. By exchanging information about illegal trafficking routes and strengthening border inspections, countries could better prevent ammunition from reaching non-state armed groups.[11]

The United Nations could also encourage developed countries to provide financial assistance and training to countries that lack the resources to properly secure their ammunition. This could include improving storage facilities and training military personnel in ammunition management.

However, delegates must consider how these measures can be implemented without interfering with national autonomy and/or limiting the ability of countries to get ammunition for legitimate defence purposes.

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[10] https://ipisresearch.be/publication/anti-diversion-measures-real-time-locating-systems/

[11] https://www.unodc.org/unodc/frontpage/2025/November/five-ways-countries-can-work-together-against-firearms-trafficking.html

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